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The Hanging As a Message to Kashmir

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Several Indian commentators appear to have been shocked by the supposed ‘secrecy’ with which the Indian government executed Mohammad Afzal Guru. Some lament now that Afzal did not receive a fair trial, while others argue the execution could have been carried out in a more civilized manner, or at a different time. Either way, many of them agree that this incident is a blot on Indian democracy. Just a blot though—as if the rest of the record has been clean. Many tried to wash away the ghastly nature of this entire episode by blaming it all on ‘politics’—petty party politics—exonerating the high politics of the state. India’s prime minister, Manmohan Singh, unable to savour the moment completely, perhaps concerned about the reaction of offended liberal sensibilities around death sentences, chastised his Home Minister Shinde for not knowing how to conduct ‘statecraft’. The state, he seemed to suggest, is subtle when executing people.

In my view, however, this execution is one of the most public events in recent memory.

Afzal’s case was a high-profile one, constantly under media glare, and throughout considerable discussions took place around it. Several books were written about the flaws of the prosecution’s case. For the previous twelve years, while Afzal awaited his fate in a tiny prison cell in Tihar, his name circulated regularly in the media or in speeches by Indian politicians. Prominent TV anchors frequently speculated about when Afzal was going to be hanged (and while breaking the news on the morning of 9 February they could hardly hide their glee). That the system was rigged against Afzal from the beginning was well known, if never acknowledged.

The execution itself took place in a very ‘open’ manner—each detail of the act of execution was made public, including Afzal Guru’s final words and emotions at the moment of his execution. Most importantly, India announced